Core Rules

SAM RULESET – Player Reference

This sheet contains everything you need to play. Omitted from the full rules are Conductor-side procedures, scenario-building notes, and character generation beyond attribute explanations. The table of contents mirrors the full document; sections that appear missing are simply not needed by players.

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1. Core Mechanics & Attributes

Three Attributes: Body, Mind, Soul.

Range: 0 – 12.

Level = (Body + Mind + Soul) ÷ 3, round down.

Attribute Modifier = Attribute score ÷ 2, round up (e.g. 7 → 4).

Attribute	Combat Role	Out-of-Combat Role
Body	Max Health, Movement, Mitigation Defense, Melee Attack bonus	Physical feats, endurance, senses, close-quarters intimidation
Mind	Turn order, Dodge Defense, Ranged Attack bonus	Puzzles, reading people, persuasion, reaction speed
Soul	Healing Threshold, Known Manifestations/Augments, Arcane Attack bonus	Creativity, luck, empathy, supernatural perception

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2. Resolution & Checks

Dice Pool

Your Attribute score determines your dice pool.

Attribute Points	Dice Pool	Rating
0 – 4	1d6	Beginner
5 – 8	2d6	Adept
9 – 12	3d6	Expert

Reading the Bones

Roll the pool, read each d6 separately.

- **1–3:** 0 Hits
- **4–5:** 1 Hit
- **6:** 1 Hit + **explode** – reroll that die immediately. If the new roll is 4+, gain another Hit. Continue rerolling only as long as you roll 6s.

Attribute modifiers are not added to dice pools unless a skill explicitly says so.

Critical Success

If every die in the pool shows a natural 6 (before any explosions), you earn a **DEVIL** (narrative or mechanical boon, Conductor's call).

Difficulty

The Conductor sets a target Hits number.

- **1 Hit:** Standard (basic terminal, sensing a lie)
- **2 Hits:** Hard (master lock, hostile guard)
- **3 Hits:** Heroic (hacking under fire)

Versus Checks (Contested)

Both parties roll. Compare total Hits.

Tiebreaker: higher Attribute Modifier.

If the check is **Derived** (two Attributes), use the highest Modifier of the two for tiebreaking.

Derived Checks

When an action draws on two Attributes, use the dice pool of the **lower** Attribute score.

Derived Check	Attributes	Examples
Grit	Body + Mind	Stealth, surgery
Aura	Body + Soul	Dancing, animal handling
Will	Mind + Soul	Deception, insight

Attribute Mastery Skills

You may declare only **one** Mastery Skill after rolling.

Level	Skill	Effect
2	**Intention**	Exhaust. Reroll any number of 1s.
6	**Precision**	Exhaust. Replace one die with your Attribute Modifier (treat as a die face; if it's a 6, it explodes).
10	**Prowess**	Once per session. Turn one die into a natural 6 (guaranteed Hit + explode).

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3. Combat Structure (The Rhythm)

Initiative & Turn Order

- PCs act in descending **Mind** attribute order. No roll needed.
- All enemies act after all PCs, **unless** the Conductor designates a Boss or Miniboss to act at a specific point in PC order (announced before combat).
- PC ties: the tied players decide order among themselves each round.

Round Flow

1. **Start of your turn:** Refresh your 2 Full Beats (4 Half-Beats) and your per-round defenses (1 Mitigate, 1 Dodge).
2. **Surprise (Round 1 only):**
   - If PCs are ambushed: enemies act first, then PCs.
   - If enemies are ambushed: PCs act first, enemies lose Swift/Cadence abilities.
   - Surprised beings cannot use Swift or Cadence.
3. **End of Round:** Apply pending Status Effect damage/procs, then remove all un-proc'd Status Effects.

Action Economy (Beats)

At the start of your turn you gain **2 Full Beats** = 4 Half-Beats. Unused Beats are lost.

Action Type	Cost	Examples
Major Action	2 HB (1 FB)	Attack (Melee/Ranged), cast a Manifestation, complex skill
Minor Action	1 HB	Interact with object, throw item, swap weapons, use item
Free Action	0 Beats	Open door, pass through window, speak one short sentence (≈6–8 words)

Movement does not cost Beats. On your turn you have a Movement pool: **Max Movement = 6 + Body attribute**. You may split movement freely between actions. There is no “Dash” action; your pool is your per-turn limit. One tile ≈ 1 meter (or whatever the table agrees).

Weapon Loadout & Inventory

- You always have **1 Melee** and **1 Ranged** primary weapon equipped. Switching between them is Free.
- You have 6 inventory slots for additional weapons/tools.
- Drawing an item from inventory costs 1 HB (Minor Action). Once drawn, it is active until swapped again.
- No ammo tracking; reloading is Free.
- No hand restrictions; a greatsword and a sniper rifle can both be primaries.

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4. Movement & Range

Range Zones (includes adjacent tiles up to the distance)

Range	Distance
Melee	Adjacent tiles only
Short	Up to 3 tiles
Medium	Up to 6 tiles
Long	Up to 9 tiles
Very Long	Up to 12 tiles

Adjacent = any tile sharing an edge. (Hex: 6; Square: 8 including diagonals.)

Fall Damage: Falls of more than 6 tiles (Medium range) deal 5 Melee damage per additional 3 tiles (Short range). The first 3 tiles of a fall are safe. This damage counts as an Attack Value against you (can be Mitigated or Dodged).

5. Attack & Defense (The Clash)

The Attack Sequence

1. The Attack

Attacker rolls: [Dice + Modifiers + Bonuses] = **Attack Value (AV)**.

2. The Defense

Defender chooses one option:

Option	Cost	Mechanic
Take It	Free	Take full damage, no reduction.
Mitigate	1 use/round	Subtract your Mitigation Defense Value (MDV) from the incoming damage: `Damage = AV - MDV`.
Dodge	1 use/round	Compare your Dodge Defense Value (DDV) to the AV. If DDV > AV, take `0` damage. If DDV ≤ AV, take full damage.

You regain your 1 Mitigate and 1 Dodge at the start of your turn.

3. Resolve Damage

If final damage ≥ 1 after defenses, subtract from HP. Status Effects and procs only trigger if at least 1 damage gets through.

Damage Calculation Order

1. Base AV (roll + modifiers)
2. **Weakness** (attacker side): if defender is Weak to this damage type, AV ×2.
3. Defender calculates DV.
4. **Resistance** (defender side): if defender is Resistant, DV ×2.
5. Status Effect penalties (e.g., Twist: –5 DV).

6. Compare AV vs DV per defense choice.
7. Final damage.

Damage Types

- **Melee / Ranged / Arcane:** standard
- **Entropy:** cannot be Mitigated or Dodged; Weak/Resistant/Immune apply normally.
- **Aeon:** true damage; ignores all defenses, resistance, immunity, and reduction.

Crits

A die showing its natural maximum (e.g., 6 on a d6) is a critical.

- **Precision (single-die weapons):** The rolled value of that die is doubled to the final AV. (e.g., 1d12 crit on a 12 → 24 added before modifiers).
- **Saturation (multi-die weapons):** Add the weapon's Chaining Factor (CF) once to the AV.
- Crits also trigger any "on crit" abilities (e.g., apply Drain).

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6. Special Combat Mechanics

Targeting Rule

You may target a specific enemy with only **one Attack Sequence** per turn (including Chained attacks and AoE). You can still attack different enemies with separate sequences.

Defensive Burn (Emergency Defense)

If you've used your Mitigate and Dodge for the round and are attacked again, you may Burn:

- **Cost:** Gain 1 Burn Token.
- **Effect:** Immediately use Mitigate OR Dodge against that attack.
- **End of your next turn:** Remove all Burn Tokens.

- **Penalty:** At the start of your next turn, each Burn Token reduces your available Beats by 1 Full Beat (two tokens = 0 Beats).
- **Limit:** Max 2 Burns per round. No Offensive Burn (no extra attacks).

Chaining (Combo Attacks)

Combine two attacks into one AV against a single enemy.

1. **Declare:** Pick a Primary Attack (full roll) and a Follow-up Attack (fixed CF).
2. **Cost:** Sum of both (typically 4 HB total).
3. **Range:** Both attacks must have matching range, or Ranged at Point Blank can chain with Melee.
4. **CF:** All attacks list their Chaining Factor. `CF = (Total Maximum Dice Value / 2) - 1` (pre-calculated on equipment).
5. **Resolution:** Roll Primary normally, then add Follow-up's CF. `Final AV = Primary Roll + Follow-up CF`.

Interactions:

- Chaining a Manifestation onto a weapon adds CF and may apply additional effects (e.g., Burst).
- If the chain includes an AoE, the whole sequence becomes that AoE; the second attack's CF is added to the damage, not repeated.
- Multi-damage-type chains: if the target is Weak to one type and Resistant to another, the multipliers cancel.

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7. Status Effects & Procs

Status Effects deal Entropy damage and cannot be Mitigated or Dodged (Weak/Resistant/Immune still apply).
A Being can have one stack of each Status Effect. Applying a second stack **procs** the effect and removes it.

Duration: All Status Effects are removed at the end of the afflicted Being's turn, unless they proc earlier.

Effect	Standard	PROC
Burst (fire/ice/explosion)	At end of turn, take 5 Entropy damage.	**Explosion:** all beings in Short Range take 5 Entropy damage; target takes 10 Entropy damage. Burst removed.
Drain (bleed/poison/siphon)	Take 5 Entropy damage if you make an Offensive Action or spend Movement. If you do neither, Drain is removed without damage.	**Backlash:** target takes 10 Entropy damage. **Siphon:** attacker heals 5 HP (Overflow). Drain removed.
Twist (dizzy/confusion)	–5 to all Defense Values (MDV/DDV) until removed.	**Impair:** target's next Attack Value is –10. **Adrenaline:** attacker gains +5 Movement immediately. Twist removed.

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8. Fading, Death & Restoration

Max HP

`10 + 1d4 per Body attribute` (maximum 12d4). Minimum 10, maximum 58, average ~34.

Fading (HP ≤ 0)

- You have **1 Full Beat** (2 HB) per turn. Cannot Chain.
- Max Movement = **3 tiles**.
- Mitigate (1/round) and Dodge (1/round) remain available.
- **Bleed Out:** At the end of your turn, take 5 Entropy damage.
- Exit Fading the moment HP is above 0.

Final Threshold (One-Shot Protection)

If a single attack would reduce your HP from above 0 to **–Max HP or worse**, set HP to `-(Max HP - 1)` instead. This protection refreshes when you heal above 0.

Single Attack = one AV (including chains), one AoE instance, or one proc. Multiple separate attacks on the same turn are not covered.

Stabilization

An adjacent ally may use a Minor Action (1 HB, once per round per target) to negate Bleed Out until you take damage again.

Death

Permanent death when HP ≤ –Max HP.

Healing

Healing Threshold (H.T.) = 3 + Mind attribute. Total healing you can receive per round from all sources cannot exceed this — unless the healing source has the **Overflow** keyword.

Out of Combat: After combat ends, you automatically heal to full HP.

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9. Manifestations & Augments

Manifestations are spells rated Tier I–VI. You may apply **one** Augment per casting.

Casting Sequence

1. **Declare** Known Manifestation and target.
2. **Form (Optional):** Choose one Augment (Solid, Liquid, Gas, Plasma).
3. **Amplify (Optional):** Spend extra Beats to Resonate and add damage dice.
4. **Create AV:** Roll like a physical attack.

Costs & Scaling

- Base Half-Beat cost = Tier number (e.g., Tier III = 3 HB).
- **Minimum cost** 2 HB (reducible via skills).
- **Resonance (Amplify):** For each additional Half-Beat spent, increase damage by one step: +1 die.
- **Forced Resonance:** Amplifying beyond your safe limit deals Aeon damage to you equal to the maximum value of every added die.

Harmonic Resonance Skill

- **Prerequisite:** Soul 2+.
- **Cost:** 2 MP per level.
- **Effect:** You may safely Amplify a number of times equal to this skill level.

Augments (The Forms)

Augment	Cost	Effect
Default (Pure Energy)	Free	Projectile/touch, Medium Range.
Crystallize (Solid)	+1 HB	Creates tangible object or physical projectile.
Liquify (Fluid)	+1 HB	Leaves a hazard puddle.
Vaporize (Gas)	+1 FB	Creates a lingering cloud/mist zone.
Ionize (Plasma)	+1 FB	Volatile, conductive energy.

10. Ability Style Guide (for Players Creating Abilities)

Follow this structure when writing custom abilities.

Line 1: [Name] (Beat cost with icon)

Line 2: (Range) (Damage & Damage Type) (Keywords) — omit if not applicable.

Effect paragraph: one block of sentences.

Optional: Flavor quote.

Beat Cost Icons:

- ○ = Free (0 Beats)
- ◐ = Half-Beat (1 HB)
- ● = Full Beat (2 HB)
- ●● = 2 Full Beats (4 HB)

Writing Rules:

- Start every sentence with a concrete verb (Manifest, Grant, Attack, Push, Spend, Create, Teleport...). Never use "You."
- No bullet lists inside the effect; a single paragraph of sentences.
- Use consistent terms: Being, Ally, Enemy, Short Range, etc.
- An ability with a damage line is an attack; the effect describes what happens on a hit (≥1 damage after defenses).
- "Perform a free Attack" is only used when granting a brand-new roll (summons, tokens).
- Use "defeats the target" instead of "reduces to 0 HP".
- For repeatable triggers: "Repeatable up to X times."
- Keywords like *Exhaust, Combative, Harmless, Swift, Cadence, Overflow* go at the start as fragments.

Templates:

- **Simple Attack:** Attack a Being.
- **Buff:** Grant an Ally [Benefit] for [Duration].

- **AoE:** Deal [Amount] [Type] damage to all Beings in [Range].
- **Manifestation example:**
  Firestarter (I) 1HB ◐ (1d4 (CF 1) Arcane) Manifest a spark that applies 🔥 Burst. "Its warmth is part of human nature."

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11. Mnemonic Skills & Advancement

Mnemonic Points (MP): currency for learning skills.

- +1 MP each time you increase an Attribute.
- +3 MP per completed Mission/Gig.

Learning Skills

- **Imprint:** Pay the listed MP cost to learn instantly.
- **Realize:** Fulfill the unlock condition during play, learn it for free at that moment.

Notable Skills:

- **Apotheosis:** Reduces a chosen Manifestation's base cost by 1 HB permanently (can be taken multiple times).
- **Harmonic Resonance** (see Section 9).

Weapon Upgrades

Weapons have 0–3 upgrade slots.

- Melee upgrades require Body attribute minimums.
- Ranged upgrades require Mind attribute minimums.
  (Exact numbers depend on the specific upgrade; consult your weapon sheet.)

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12. Environmental Rules (Downpour)

When rain falls, the Conductor rolls once on the Downpour table at the start of the mission. The effect applies to all combats for the whole mission. Players know which

Downpour is active before they commit to action.

d12	Effect
1	1 Beat maximum per turn.
2	Cannot Chain attacks.
3	Max Movement halved.
4	Start each combat with Drain.
5	All Attack Values halved (round down).
6	All Defense Values halved (round down).
7	All CF values halved (round down).
8	Mitigation unavailable (includes Burn).
9	Dodge unavailable (includes Burn).
10	One weapon (your choice) has 0 CF.
11	No Attribute Modifiers on Attack Values.
12	All Attack/Defense Values suffer –5 (minimum final value 1).

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13. Quick Reference

Action Costs

Cost	Action
2 HB (1 FB)	Major Action (Attack, Manifestation)
1 HB	Minor Action (Use Item, Draw Weapon)
0	Free Action (open door, speak)
Movement	Free, pool = 6 + Body

Defenses

Defense	Uses/Round	Effect
Take It	Unlimited	Full damage
Mitigate	1	Reduce damage by MDV
Dodge	1	All or nothing vs AV
Burn	Up to 2 (costs Burn Token)	Extra defense, lose Beats next turn

Status Effects (Summary)

- **Burst:** 5 Entropy dmg end-of-turn; PROC: AoE 5 dmg, target +5.
- **Drain:** 5 dmg if move/attack; PROC: 10 dmg + attacker heals 5 Overflow.
- **Twist:** –5 DV; PROC: target AV –10, attacker +5 Movement.

Range Bands

Range	Distance
Melee	Adjacent
Short	≤3 tiles
Medium	≤6 tiles
Long	≤9 tiles
Very Long	≤12 tiles